

labelling stickers were affixed on the racks and a similar rack was replicated at their godown (warehouse). The refill list could now be categorised rack-wise. Thus, on a refill trip to the godown, each rack would have to be visited only once. Making a list of out-of-rack and out-of-stock items now took 90 minutes less, which meant more time for the sales counter.

### Simple Products, Smart Use

While this was a process upgrade, the next technology upgrade came in the form of a calculator that displayed sub totals. While a customer was purchasing goods, his sub total (amount till the last purchase) would be read out to him if required. He could thus budget his purchase, and this pleased the more budget-conscious shoppers at Welcome.

In 1987, a company called Bradma introduced a programmable printer. This was the next obvious buy for Uttamchandani. Apart from being able to give his customers a printed and itemised bill (name, price, amount for each item and grand total), there was hot-key access to the 20 hottest-selling items—meaning these could be keyed in with one stroke—thus speeding up customer turnaround time. Daily sales reports could be generated, too. Two of such printers were soon added to the store's "IT resources."

It was in 1991 that these gave way to the Bradma Cash Register. Memory increased to 300 items, and purchase price of products could also be stored. Margins increased on account of this simple utility: different wholesalers would quote different prices, or the same wholesaler would quote different prices at different times. Because of the facility to cross-check at the turn of a key, purchases became cost-effective.

The 300-item-memory limitation was bypassed by the purchase of another next-gen cash register with an additional card as expanded memory. But since the memory was volatile, a power failure meant having to reprogram it, which took six to seven days.

### Enter The PC

Uttamchandani has a simple philosophy—time wasted is money lost—so when he first heard of computers, it was the non-volatile nature of the memory that attracted him: reprogramming

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Rack replicated at the warehouse

would become a thing of the past! In 1993, the PC arrived at Welcome Store. One comprising a 286 processor, a 40 MB hard disk and a green-tone monochrome monitor replaced the cash register.

The first D-Base program for billing and inventory control did not impress Uttamchandani. He had a simple reason: 857 was the code for Lux soap. Two bars were billed by the instruction 2\*857 followed by [Enter] in the case of the cash register. In the software, the same process meant the following key sequence:

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857
[Enter]
2
[Enter]
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Two keystrokes of [Enter] for every item meant precious customer turnaround time! Within a week, Uttamchandani decided to change this. He contacted his friend, philosopher and guide - Padmanab Desai, a computer expert who also teaches MCA students. At eleven in the night, Uttamchandani landed up at his doorstep, and sat through the night till the change in input had been implemented.

But as the business grew there was obvious crowding at the store's single billing terminal, so the next step was to procure another machine and set up a LAN. Novell 2 was the program he used for this. But the cash drawer remained one, and was operated in sequence according to the billing cycle: whoever was processing a bill would operate the cash drawer, while the other person would wait to access it. At the end of the day, the "cash in hand" reading on the system had to tally with the cash in the drawers.

While this took care of billing, certain shortcomings were soon realised. There was the need to consider different sales prices for product sub-categories, generate stock statements and rack filling lists, and re-order reports.

### The Need To Upgrade

In 1996, a software upgrade using Clipper and C+ was completed in a 90-day timeframe by Vadorada-based Infosoft company. The salient features of the improvement were Stock Validation Control (a user would not be able to bill a sale without "stock in hand" or placing an order for purchase); cash in hand report; rack filling report; re-order list categorised according to supplier; outstanding receipts and payments report; and purchase order generation —this was updated even for instant purchases (those made even while the customer was waiting for it).



Smart Working is the way for Satish Uttamchandani